

and above what you're investing into retirement accounts if a bridge period applies to you. You'll lose a ton of money in taxes and penalties if you try to crack open your retirement accounts early, so don't even consider it. Instead, make sure you've got enough money set aside somewhere else to live on between the time you leave work and when you can fully access your retirement funds. This becomes a lot easier once you pay off your home, by the way. You can throw your old mortgage payment into a mutual fund every month to build up an early-retirement account. And if you max out your 401(k) and IRA contributions for the year, a simple mutual fund is a great option for extra investing. Even if you don't need it for early retirement, it'll still be there growing over time and adding to your net worth.

Last, as I've said several times, never stop budgeting. Your budget will be the grease in the gears of your wealth-building engine; it'll keep things running smoothly for the rest of your life. You will never outgrow the need for careful budgeting, so settle in and get used to it for the long haul.